

Friends: The One With The Ick Factor (S1E22)

An English Study Guide:
Secrets, Slang & Surprises

Level: Intermediate/Advanced (BI-B2)

Focus: Conversational Idioms,
Workplace Slang, and 90s Culture

1. SCENE A. TEASER (3)
INT. COFFEE HOUSE - DAY - (DAY 1)
(Monica, Rachel, Phoebe, Chandler,
Joey, Ross)

2. ACT I. Scene B (4)
INT. COFFEE HOUSE - LATER -
(DAY 1)
(Monica, Phoebe, Rachel, Chandler,
Ross, Joey)

3. ACT I. Scene 2 (9)
INT. CHANDLER'S OFFICE - DAY
(Chandler, Phoebe)



The Age Gap (Monica & Ethan)



Plot: Monica (26) lies and says she is 22. Her new boyfriend Ethan lies and says he is a college senior.

Secret: He is actually 17 years old.

9. ACT II. Scene M (37)
INT. MONICA AND RACHEL'S APT. -
SEVERAL DAYS LATER - (DAY 31)
(Monica, Rachel, Phoebe, Joey,
Chandler, Ross)

Episode Breakdown: Three Secrets, Three Stories

The Workplace (Chandler & Phoebe)



Plot: Chandler gets promoted to boss. Phoebe takes a short-term job as his secretary.

Secret: Chandler's former friends at work now hate him and mock his voice.



Dreams & Beepers (Rachel & Ross)



Plot: Rachel starts having romantic dreams about the guys. Ross eagerly waits for his ex-wife to go into labor.

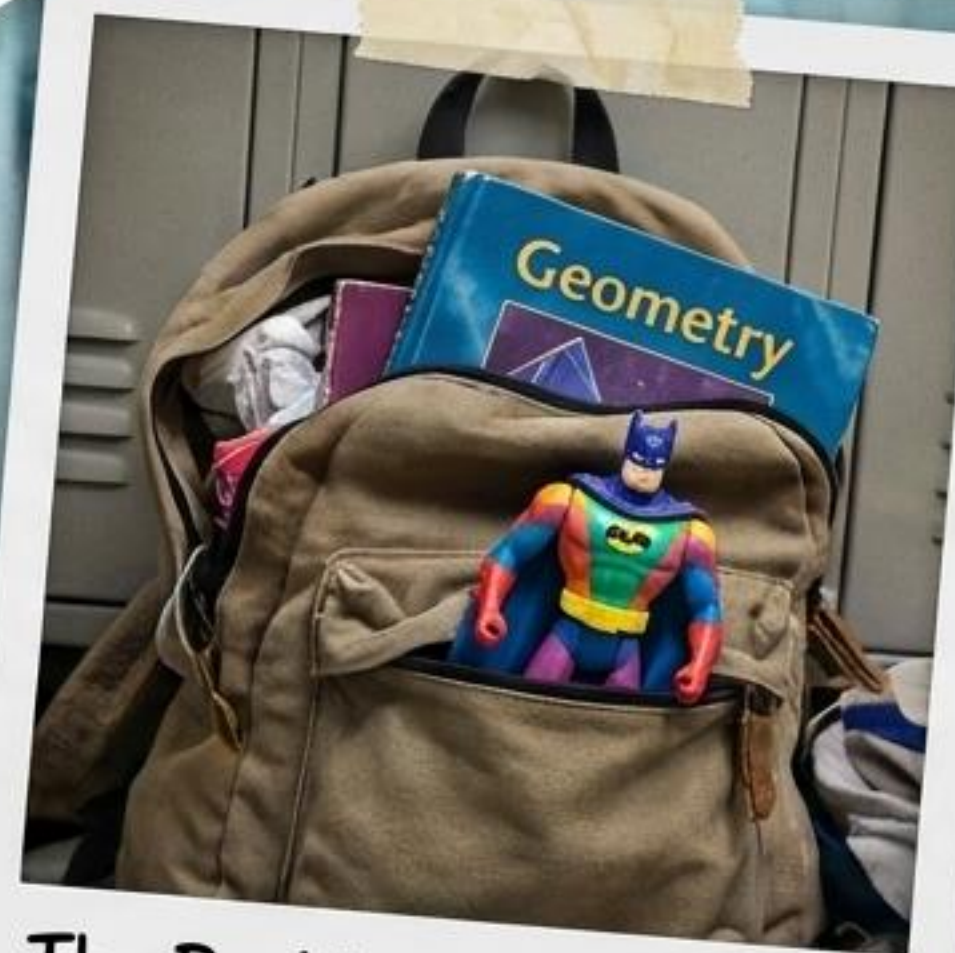
Secret: Ross is extremely jealous of Chandler and Joey's role in Rachel's dreams.



The Illusion: A mature senior in college.

Storyline 1: Romance vs. Reality

Monica thinks she has found the perfect guy. The romance is perfect—until they both decide to tell the truth about their ages. The revelation destroys the romance instantly.



The Reality: A 17-year-old high school student.

Vocab Spotlight: The Ick Factor

Y-Axis
Romance
Level

The Truth
is Revealed

Felon (noun): A criminal.
Monica jokes that
dating a 17-year-old
makes her a felon in
48 states.

To pass for [age] (phrasal verb):
To look young or old enough to
be believed as a certain age.
Example: Monica (26) thinks
she can pass for 22.

The Ick (noun):
A sudden feeling of
disgust that makes
you instantly lose
romantic interest in
someone.

Virgin (noun):
Someone who has
never had sex.
Ethan admits this is
his first time.

THE ICK

X-Axis
Time on Date

Cultural Context: Explaining the Jokes

I'm Joan Collins!

When Monica learns Ethan's age, she panics and says, "I'm Joan Collins!"

Joan Collins is a famous British actress known for playing glamorous older women who date much younger men. Ethan is too young to even know who she is!



Too young to know her!

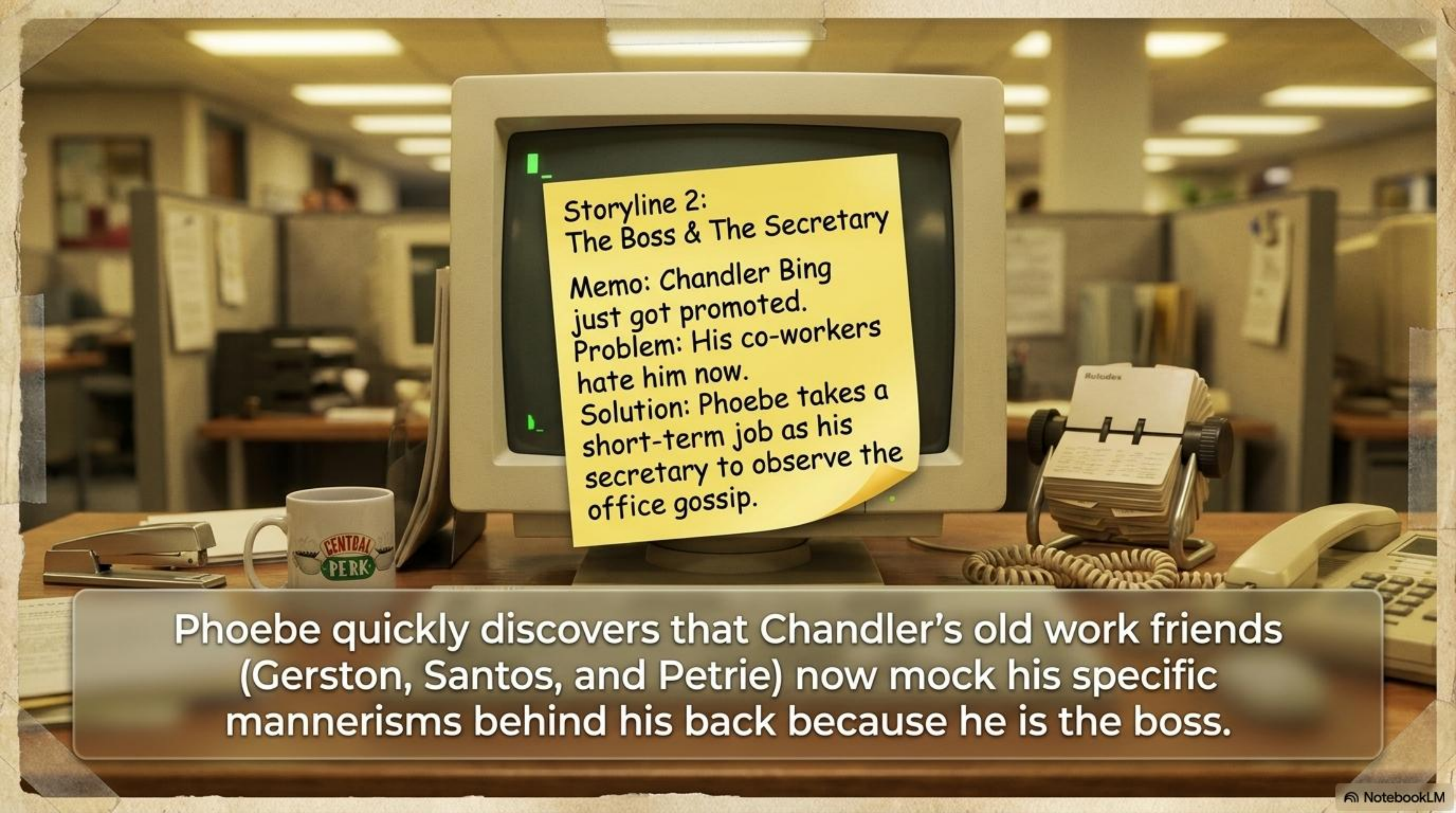


I just had sex with someone who wasn't alive during the bi-centennial!

The Bicentennial (1976)

Monica says: "I just had sex with someone who wasn't alive during the Bicentennial."

The Bicentennial was America's 200th birthday in 1976. This is Monica's funny way of realizing Ethan was born after 1976.



Storyline 2:
The Boss & The Secretary

Memo: Chandler Bing
just got promoted.
Problem: His co-workers
hate him now.
Solution: Phoebe takes a
short-term job as his
secretary to observe the
office gossip.

Phoebe quickly discovers that Chandler's old work friends (Gerston, Santos, and Petrie) now mock his specific mannerisms behind his back because he is the boss.

BOSS

Employee File

Vocab Spotlight: Office English

Get promoted (verb):
To receive a higher position
and more power at work.

Secretary / Receptionist (noun):
A person who answers phones
and manages schedules.

Short-term work (noun):
A temporary job. Phoebe
only needs the job until
her massage clients return.

PHOEBE:
Well, I just need a little
short-term work until I get
my massage clients back.



Make fun of (phrasal verb):
To tease or mock someone.

TIMESHEET				
NAME <i>Timesheet</i>				
DATE	DESCRIPTION	DATE	TIME	COFFE
10-10	Bacon Toldary			
10-11	Phoebe Healing	20		
15-00	Concert Meeting	90		
18-19	Intro. Governance	75		
		30		

Pronunciation Focus: The Chandler Intonation

Normal English Stress

Could this report be any later?



Normal Soundwave

Normally, speakers stress the most important information words (report, later).

Chandler's Stress

Could this **BE** any later?



Chandler's Soundwave

Chandler creates his unique sarcasm by placing heavy, unnatural stress on the auxiliary verb "be". His coworkers copy this to make fun of him (e.g., "My scone!").

PHOEBE: Oh, yeah. You know...
"Could your report be any later?"

CHANDLER: I don't talk like that.

JOEY: Yeah, you do. Like... "I don't think that was my cookie."

ROSS: "The hills are alive with the sound of music."

JOEY: "My scone. My sc... NotebookLM

Storyline 3: Subconscious Dreams & Digital Beeps

Rachel starts having
vivid, romantic
dreams about
Chandler and Joey,
making Ross
incredibly jealous.

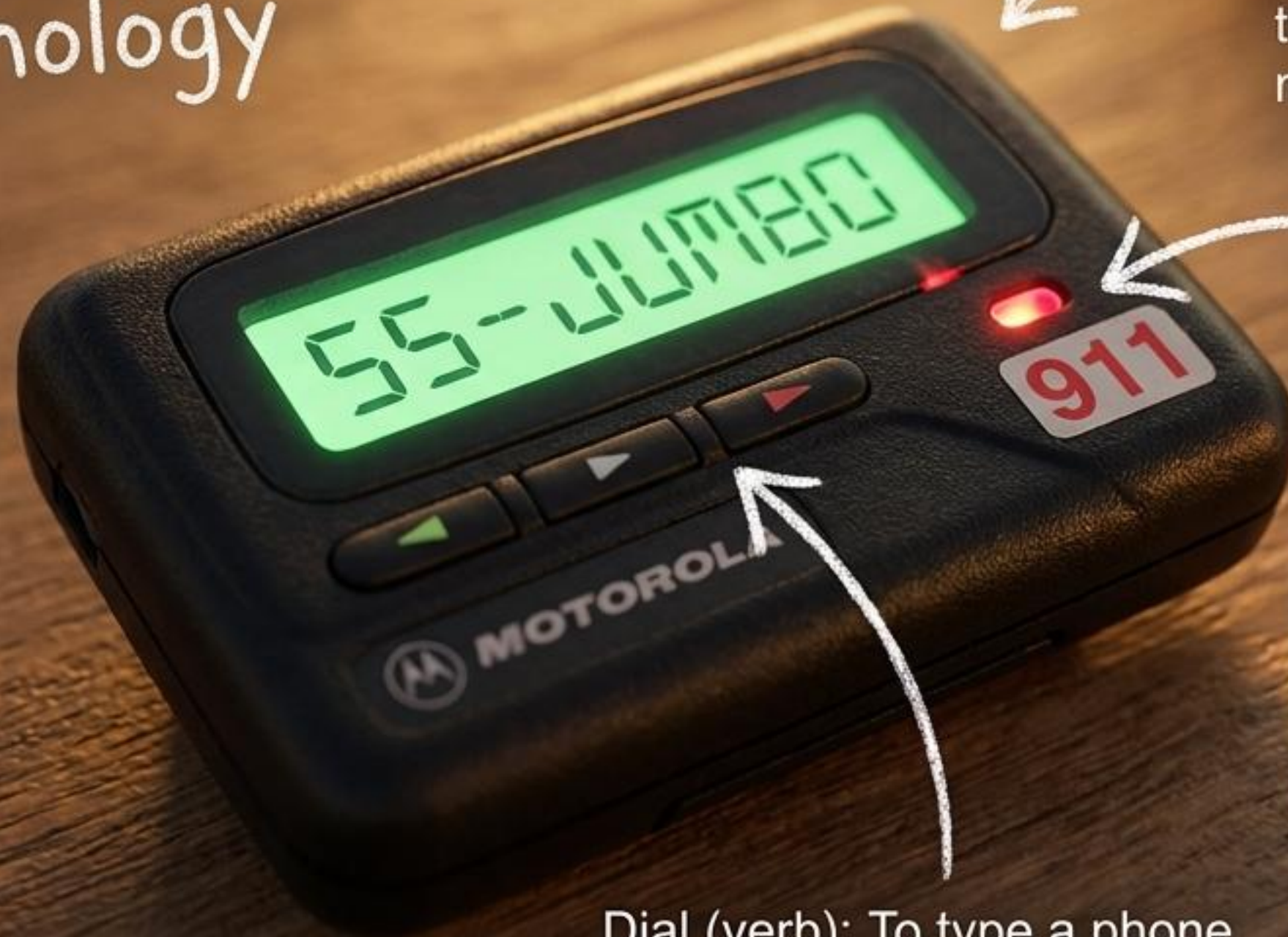
(Ross is NOT happy!)

Ross is waiting for his
ex-wife, Carol, to give birth.
Because it is 1995, he must
carry a pager so she can
reach him in an emergency.

(Beep beep!)



Vocab Spotlight: 90s Technology

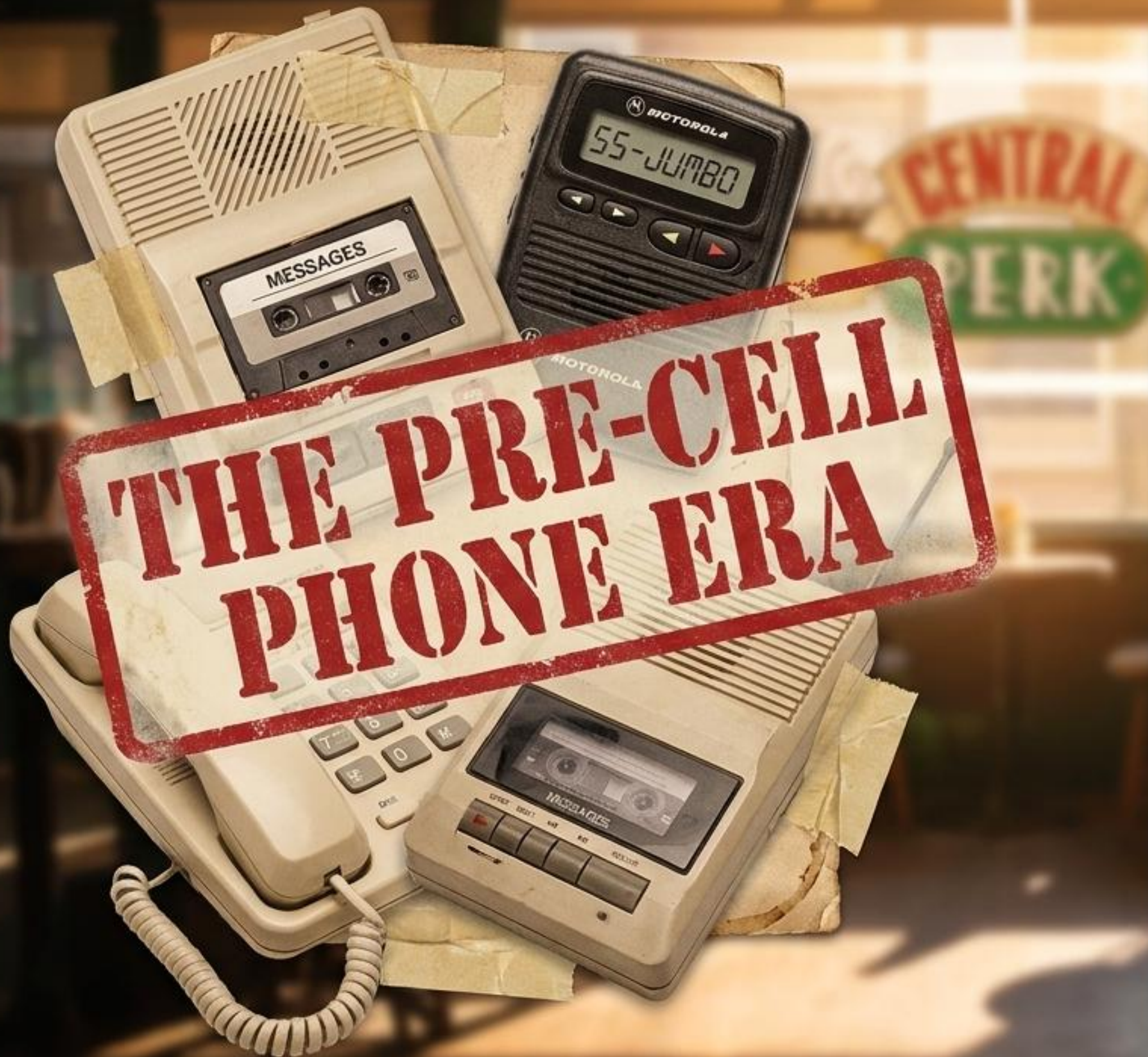


Beeper / Pager (noun):
A pre-cell phone device
that receives short numeric
messages.

Go into labor (verb
phrase): The physical
process of a woman
starting to give birth.

Subconscious (noun):
The part of your
mind that creates
dreams you cannot
control.

Dial (verb): To type a phone
number. Carol must dial
55-JIMBO to reach Ross.



Episode Synthesis:
Comedy Before Smartphones.

Bullet 1: This entire episode's comedy relies on 1995 technology.

Bullet 2: If smartphones existed, Ross would not get wrong-number pages for a man named 'Andre' (55-JUMBO vs 55-JIMBO).

Bullet 3: If caller ID existed, Phoebe wouldn't have to answer Chandler's landline desk phone to screen his calls.

Takeaway: Understanding 90s tech is essential to understanding 90s humor!

Comprehension Check: True or False?

- ☐ 1. Ethan tells Monica that he is a senior in college.
- ☐ 2. Phoebe takes a short-term job to work as Chandler's boss.
- ☐ 3. Ross uses a beeper to know when Carol goes into labor.
- ☐ 4. Rachel's first romantic dream is about Ross.



Comprehension Check: Short Answer

1. Why did Phoebe lose her massage clients, forcing her to look for office work?

2. Why did Monica decide to break up with Ethan, even though she liked him?

3. What specific number does Carol need to type into Ross's pager to signal that she is having the baby?

Answer Key & Explanations

1. Ethan tells Monica that he is a senior in college.

True (He later confesses he is a high school senior).

2. Phoebe takes a short-term job to work as Chandler's boss.

False (She works as his secretary).

3. Ross uses a beeper to know when Carol goes into labor.

True (His code is 55-JIMBO).

4. Rachel's first romantic dream is about Ross.

False (Her first dream is about Chandler).



1. Why did Phoebe lose her massage clients, forcing her to look for office work?

She taught them a massage-yourself-at-home workshop, so they didn't need her anymore.

PHOEBE: ...I taught a "Massage Yourself At Home" workshop, and so they are.

2. Why did Monica decide to break up with Ethan, even though she liked him?

He was 17 years old, which gave her 'the ick' because he was too young.

3. What specific number does Carol need to type into Ross's pager to signal that she is having the baby?

She needs to punch in the code 911.

Your Turn: Discussion & Speaking Practice

Prompt 1: Have you ever experienced “the ick” on a date? What caused it?

Prompt 2: Do you think Chandler’s employees were right to treat him differently after he was promoted to boss?

Prompt 3: How much harder was dating and working before the invention of cell phones?

Practice answering these out loud or write your answers in a journal!